Heart'Bit'-Burner

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Heart'Bit'-Burner

by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

In an overly connected world, where everything seems to have become electronic and artificial, nothing ever feels natural anymore. People install augmentations to enhance their bodies, provided by factions that have become the new ruling forces of the world, and all it takes is your memory.
A “moment of respite”, some call it; a “soft reset”, to be precise.
The closest to feeling natural again.
It’s a moment of innocence; a blank slate before the artificial world sucks you back into its never-ending chaos.
And so, a woman wakes up with no clue as to who she is, where she is, or who the man in front of her could possibly be…

First Augmentation

Chapter Notes

Well, be welcomed to yet another one of my fics :D
Another one I completed thanks to the WIP Big Bang event!!

This time, based on this videogame from steam called Bitburner!
The concept is simple: The world is almost entirely digital, everyone's a hacker to some degree, more or less ethical, ofc, and… you can buy and install augments to improve your stats! So, every time you buy one, the price of the next one u buy will be increased as long as it remains uninstalled, and the enhancements won't take effect until the installation. The thing is: when u install, you have to restart from scratch…

So, what you'll read here, between LS and Casta, are the two possible approaches: buy and install immediately, or gather and queue, bearing the increasing costs…

Anyways, enough rambling
Please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

In an overly connected world, where everything seems to have become electronic and artificial, nothing ever feels natural anymore. People install augmentations to enhance their bodies, provided by factions that have become the new ruling forces of the world, and all it takes is your *memory*.

A “moment of respite”, some call it; a “soft reset”, to be precise.

The closest to feeling natural again.

It’s a moment of innocence; a blank slate before the artificial world sucks you back into its never-ending chaos.

And so, a woman wakes up with no clue as to who she is, *where* she is, or who the man in front of her could possibly be.

—Welcome back, Light Spinner.

—Who…— she tried to ask, her voice groggy and slightly muffled by a veil.

—I’m your apprentice, Micah— the man replied, standing up from the chair he was sitting on. —Can you move?

—No…

—Take a moment, then.

—What's going on?

"Who?" and "What?" were always the first two questions asked by people after installing an augmentation.

So Micah was prepared.

Light Spinner had planned everything very carefully and entrusted him with the task of restoring her memory. All he had to do was follow the little electronic journal's instructions, and reintroduce her to herself.

This was the first time so, of course, Micah was initially at a loss. He awkwardly explained to Light Spinner who she was, what had happened, how she gave him this task and instructions, and that the installation of her first augmentation had been a success.

He gave her a quick summary of her life, following the bullet points list written by herself, and finally decided it was time to leave her to rest.

—You should be able to eat soon, once you're stable enough and can move on your own without stumbling— Micah explained, standing up. —Do you need anything?

—No.

—Alright, then…— he was saying, when a knock on the door interrupted him, yet he didn't hesitate to open it. —Who- Casta?— he reacted, surprised.

—Oh, you're still here…

—I was leaving, but… what are *you* doing here?

—I…— she began, hesitant. Clearing her throat, she replied —Our… faction sent me to check on her and see how the installation went.

—Mystacor… sent *you*!?

—Well, yes. It's among my duties.

—I see— he sighed. —Fine. Do you want me to stay?

—No, no. I just need a moment to talk with her. That's all— she assured him, smiling gently.

—Oh, alright, then. I'll take my leave.

With that, Micah farewelled and left Light Spinner's apartment.

The women were now alone in a dimly lit room.

—Who are you?— she finally asked, pushing herself up.

—I am… Micah's sister— the young woman began. —Do you… remember me?

—No.

—I'm… Castaspella— she decided to say, clenching her hands, resisting the urge to reach for hers.

—He didn't mention you.

—I supposed so— she slightly nodded, looking away. She knew it would hurt, but *knowing* made no difference. Trying to avoid the uncomfortable silence, she asked —Mind if I turn the rest of the lights on?

—I don't even know where the switches are.

Castaspella tilted her head to the side, curious.

—You got rid of switches long ago— she pointed out. —Wasn't that among your notes?— she then asked, before picking up a remote control.

Light Spinner watched as she turned the ceiling lights on, turned the nightstand lamp off, and even activated the central heater.

—How do you know…

—We… have a lot to discuss— Castaspella interrupted, refraining from approaching the woman who now sat on the bed. —But we should probably wait until you're more stable.

—I'm fine.

—If you can't walk on your own…

—I said I'm fine. What do we have to discuss?

—Alright— Castaspella sighed. —There are things Micah doesn't know… about you. And about me.

—Like what?

She looked away, biting back a smirk, and asked back —Can we continue this conversation over dinner? My treat.

—Sure. I wouldn't turn down free food— Light Spinner replied, standing up. —And I'm starving.

—Are you sure you can walk?

—Absolutely— the woman insisted, struggling to get to the door but mostly moving in a straight line.

Castaspella giggled, shaking her head in amusement, and promptly followed.

Perhaps the neon lights illuminating the dark streets made the woman slightly dizzy, or perhaps it *was* too soon for Light Spinner to be outside already… Whatever the reason, she obediently followed Castaspella's lead until they reached a cozy little restaurant.

—I don't expect you to recognize this place but…

—It does look familiar— Light Spinner interrupted, making Castaspella turn back to look at her in surprise.

—It's… *our* favourite ramen shop— she revealed, a glimmer of hope in her eyes.

—Ramen?

Smiling gently, she took Light Spinner to a table and they sat side by side.

—We have a lot to talk about…

—I reckon you mean things I don't remember because of my augmentation.

—Exactly— she nodded. —Things that… Micah doesn't know about either.

—Right… And why would *you* know things about me that he doesn't know if I personally tasked him with restoring my memory?

—We… decided so.

Light Spinner let out a long sigh and her stomach rumbled noisily, making Castaspella giggle.

—Food first, big revelations later.

—Of course— she chuckled, waving at a waiter. —We'd like a bowl of Hiyashi Chuka for her, and a bowl of Shio Ramen for me. Thank you.

The woman waited until they were alone again to ask —What did you order for me?

—It's… a kind of cold ramen. You like it more than the regular hot soups— Castaspella explained with a smile. —Mine is a rather simpler one. I enjoy the noodles more than anything, and here they make Shio Ramen with *a lot* of noodles— she giggled.

—I see…

—Sorry, I know. Food first…

—I said that *revelations* have to wait until I have something in my stomach— Light Spinner pointed out. —If you want to ramble about something else in the meantime, I'm all ears.

—Really?

—I wouldn't like to wait in silence. That'd be awkward— she replied, rolling her eyes at Castaspella's enraptured gaze.

—Right, right…— she muttered, looking away with a faint blush. —Well, I can totally do that…

After a while of info-dumping about ramen, the food finally arrived and Castaspella took a moment to gather her thoughts, mindlessly observing the woman carefully eating without taking off her veil.

—You were right— Light Spinner said before she could speak.

—Huh?

—The soup- The ramen. I really like this.

—Oh, that's good…

—I reckon the *big revelations* will explain how you know me so well— she said, a bit smug.

—Yeah… But I'm not sure where to begin, to be honest.

—You said *we* decided that Micah wouldn't know whatever you have to tell me… That's a good start for me— Light Spinner proposed, stirring her soup with her pair of chopsticks.

—Of course. Right! So, um… the thing is: my brother doesn't know about *us*. Despite- Um, despite how many years we have been together, we decided *not* to tell him.

—We… are a couple?

—We were, at least, yes…— Castaspella nodded, looking down at her ramen. —But keeping the secret for so long makes it feel… I don't know, like an illusion. After all, only I recall it now— she admitted with a sad smile.

As she finally began eating, Light Spinner swallowed a bit rushedly and incredulously asked —How and when did we meet?

—I imagined you'd ask— she chuckled. —Well, I was twenty-four back then… I was invited to Mystacor's faction; you already worked with Micah, and I joined the team. But- I-I mean, we only got together sometime after I turned twenty-eight.

She listened attentively, trying to piece everything together, yet something was off.

Confused, she dared ask —Exactly how old are you?

Normally, that would be quite a rude question, but… Castaspella was expecting it, and the old woman had never been one to follow social norms, anyways.

Blushing, she admitted —I'm thirty-five…

—*Seven years*!?— Light Spinner let out, astonished as she quickly did the math. —And yet… not only does your brother *not know*, but you also allowed me to go through the augment installation *knowing* I would forget about you!?

—Pretty much— she nodded. —Micah never realized because we worked together a lot since the beginning, so… it always seemed like everything was merely professional— she smiled, holding back a chuckle. —And now I'll be working closely with you again since I have to guide you through returning to your work. I'll make sure you start earning money as soon as possible and, well, whatever you may need, I'll be there to help!

—I see— Light Spinner sighed, before slurping some more noodles. —But I'm sure I can manage on my own. And that doesn't really answer my question…

—Bea… it took you *so* long to gather enough money for that first augmentation— Castaspella began, her tone pitying her, much to the woman's dismay. —That's… precisely why I didn't want to stop you from installing it.

—That expensive?

—Six billions…

—Holy fuck— she muttered, genuinely surprised. She then cleared her throat, put her chopsticks down, and asked —Do you have any augmentations?

Castaspella couldn't hold back a small smile.

She was showing interest in her…

—None installed, no— she denied. —Like you, I bought my first augmentation recently, the same one, actually, but… my strategy is slightly different from yours.

—How so?— Light Spinner further inquired, picking up her bowl to drink the remaining soup while attentively listening to her.

—I don't want to "restart" several times. I'd rather buy all the available augmentations I can possibly get, and then install them all together.

Once again, the woman was quite confused.

She put down the now-empty bowl, and pointed out —But, if I understood Micah correctly, the prices go up for each uninstalled augmentation you possess.

—That's right. Which is why I began with the most expensive one— she explained, blushing again. —I think it's the best plan for me…

—You must be very patient— Light Spinner commented, raising a brow.

Castaspella's embarrassment only increased and she rushed to finish her ramen, trying to hide her reddened face.

Soon enough, the young woman paid the bill and they both walked out of the shop.

The night was cold but bearable.

It was actually pretty beautiful…

Neon lights illuminated the streets more than the full moon in the sky, no stars were visible, but the colors around them created a gorgeous albeit artificial environment.

—Thank you for accepting my invitation… and listening.

—Of course— Light Spinner nodded. —Shall I accompany you home?

—I- Su-sure! I'd like that— Castaspella stammered, blushing again before accepting.

—Lead the way, then…

—It's not far— she assured her, starting to walk. —Would you like a cup of tea or coffee when we arrive?

—If you don't mind inviting me in… either would be fine— Light Spinner smirked.

As Castaspella said, her place was barely a few blocks away, and it wasn't long before they were sitting at the kitchen table, each with a mug of coffee.

—How is it?

—Hmm… I can't believe- Does this have azahar water?

—It does. You taught me how to prepare this coffee; your favourite— she explained.

That made Light Spinner freeze for a moment, confused, but it didn't take her much to realize that had to be true.

She couldn't quite describe the feelings this coffee sparked inside her, she didn't want to dwell too much on them…

Yet there was another feeling, one that Castaspella herself had been inspiring, that now urged her to accept it.

Gratitude.

She didn't need anyone to tell her she's not one to express gratitude, but she could make an exception for this gentle young woman.

—I appreciate it— she finally sighed, reaching across the table for Castaspella's hand. —I can tell that you… love me deeply.

—I do— she immediately nodded, catching a sob and holding back tears.

—But I must apologize, I suppose. I know nothing about you now— she went on, feeling *strange* for apologizing too. Another thing she *loathed*. —While I certainly feel *something strong*, I can't quite name it yet, so I'd rather not give you hope.

However, the spark of hope had already been lit.

—I understand, of course— Castaspella accepted, smiling gently. —We had agreed to take as much time as necessary; if it happened once, it can happen again, and I'm willing to wait— she assured her. —Honestly, I didn't think you'd be so nice to me already, so this alone is more than I hoped for— she then added, chuckling. —I just… want to know it's all genuine. I mean, I don't want you to be with me out of compromise; I'd rather earn your love all over again.

—Of course— Light Spinner breathlessly laughed. —Sounds cheesy, but I had the sensation that you'd say that— she smirked. The young woman only chuckled more and it stirred something inside her. The unnamed feeling… What if… —I have to ask something from you, however.

—Tell me.

—A kiss— she bluntly said, surprising her. Right after, she clarified —Don't feel pressured to accept, but I- Ahem… I must admit, everything in me seems to want it, which is making me curious, to say the least.

—I don't mind, Bea— she smiled. Castaspella gave her a longing look and squeezed her hand, standing up with her. —Through the veil?

—No, I'll take it off. You've already seen my face, for sure…

—I don't want you to feel uncomfortable…

—I imagine. But, rest assured, I wouldn't do it if I were— she insisted, carefully removing it.

—A-alright.

Hesitantly, they closed the distance and shared a brief kiss.

It was enough of an answer for Light Spinner.

The tightness in her chest and the burning desire to deepen the kiss… that was passion right there.

But was it *love*?

—Much appreciated— she muttered.

—It's been only two days…— Castaspella sighed, seemingly reluctant to pull away. —Yet I miss you so much already…

The young woman let out a yawn and stretched a bit.

She felt comfortable and warm…

But where was she?

It took her a moment too long to realize she had fallen asleep.

She was in bed.

Groggy, she brushed her eyes and pushed herself up.

Little by little, the room came into view; rays of sunshine entered through the windowsill, specks of dust floated in front of her, and the absolute silence made Castaspella forget for a moment how utterly artificial the world actually is.

Maybe that's how it felt after an augment installation…

—Morning.

—Ah!

The young woman almost jumped out of bed upon hearing none other than Light Spinner speak next to her.

She was smugly resting on the other side of the bed, veil and clothes on, but her hair was messy enough that it was obvious she had slept there.

—Scaredy-cat…

—What are you doing here!?

—What does it look like?— she asked back, snarky.

—Shit… Oh, shit— Castaspella began muttering in panic. —I'm so, *so* ashamed. I-I don't know how this happened, I can't remember a thing… A-and I'm sorry, this was *not* supposed to happen! I-I never meant to pressure you to do this or anything… Really— she then blurted out, almost breathless at the end.

—Alright, alright— Light Spinner sighed, moving the sheets away to stand up. —First of all, calm down— she ordered. —Second: I did nothing I didn't want to do, so you can *stop* with the apologies…

—But…

—Listen to me— the woman interrupted. —We're in this situation precisely because you panicked like this last night. Alright? So you better calm down before I call your brother…

—No, no! I'm calm! I'm… calm… Just tell me what happened, then— Castaspella pleaded, sitting down on the bed again, keeping the sheets wrapped around her, despite *not* being naked or anything.

—What's the last thing you remember?

—You… asked me for a kiss.

—Precisely. That happened, and we may have gotten carried away…

—Oh, no…

—It wouldn't have been that bad if you- Ugh… You couldn't deal with it and basically downed a bottle of sake before I could stop you— Light Spinner explained, annoyed. —I warned you this would happen, but you didn't want to listen, did you!?

Castaspella looked down, even more ashamed now, and shook her head slightly.

—Then, why are you here?

—Because I'm stupid? A fool?— she replied, rolling her eyes. —Who knows? For some reason, I didn't want to leave you alone like that…

—Tha-thank you— the young woman stammered. —I'm so sorry for that.

Smirking, she didn't hesitate to propose —If you're sorry, just treat me to another cup of coffee for breakfast, and we're good.

After a brief and quiet breakfast, Light Spinner was getting ready to leave, but something made her stop at the door.

—What is it?

—Yesterday you mentioned… being sent from Mystacor's faction…

—Oh, that- No, well, I mean… It was just an excuse, you know, so that Micah wouldn't… suspect— Castaspella explained, looking down.

—So they are not…

—Oh, no, yes! I- That is, Mystacor wants you back, of course! But they have other people who handle recruitment, you know?

—Ah… Of course— she nodded. —Well, I reckon I have to reinsert myself into my life and routine now, so I shall take my leave…

—Yes, you… probably have a lot to do. Don’t hesitate to ask for help if you need anything.

—I shall— she laughed. —Do I take it as an invitation to return, then?

—You’re completely free to come and go. After all… you have the key.

—Do I?

—Your biometrics open the door, silly— Castaspella chuckled.

Chapter End Notes

How was that for a first chapter!? :D

I hope you liked it, and that it wasn't too confusing or anything…

I am sorry to say… this will keep happening <("^_^)

Oh, a comment on the augmentation price: at the time I wrote this chapter, "6 billions" was the highest I had paid for an augment… Currently, I'm gathering 3 *trillions*, so it could most certainly have been worse lol

Anyways, if you're curious about the "will keep happening"…
Hint: each chapter name refers the number of augments that have been installed…
Except for the last one, and no, next chapter is *not* the second augmentation… (/v\)

Hint 2: there's an achievement in Bitburner for queuing 40 augments, which I'm currently pursuing, so… that says a lot already XD

ENOUGH SPOILERS!!

See you next week!! Thank you for reading!!

Third Augmentation

Chapter Notes

Hi everyone! It's Wednesday again! :D
You know what that means!!!

Welcome back to another chapter!!

As you can tell from the title, Light Spinner has not stopped.
If you're thinking "Poor Casta", trust me, this is *nothing* yet…

But I should probably just let you read before I accidentally spoil you XD

Please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It wasn't long before it happened again.

And again…

Castaspella implemented the same strategy a second and third time…

They had the same conversation a second and third time…

And Light Spinner was just as baffled as always.

—Just… why aren't *you* the one to welcome me after the installations?

—As I've told you before: Micah doesn't- he *can't* know, so I'd have no plausible reason to do it in his stead. *He* is your apprentice.

—I can always instruct it and that should be reason enough…

—Bea… What would you tell him when he asks why you want *me* to do it?— Castaspella insisted, expression tired.

—Because I say so!— the woman replied, indignant. As a tense silence settled between them, Light Spinner stared at her and only then realized —We have discussed this too before, haven't we?

—Yes…

—And since this was my third augmentation, last two times we agreed to… keep things like this…

—Bea, I- Trust me, we've gone through all possibilities. In the end, you had to agree it was better to keep things as they are…— the young woman calmly explained, placing a hand over Light Spinner's on the table.

She took a deep breath, hesitated for a moment, and then asked —How long have we been together now?

—With intermissions, it's going to be nine years soon…

—Nine… and you- *we* haven't let anyone know?

—Bea, what would happen if you don't fall for me again the next time you install an augment or the time that follows? I-I mean, you can't even be sure you will *this time*!

—I'll sound very stupid, but I've fallen for you since the moment you began rambling about our life together before the augmentations— Light Spinner chuckled. —You should see your face while at it, how your eyes seem to shine, and your smile only gets wider…

—Oh, my, please stop— Castaspella pleaded, blushing deeply and covering her face. —Who are you and what did you do to my Bea?

—I wouldn't admit it if I weren't trying to prove a point, so you can trust I'm being honest— she assured her. —Which I'm slowly regretting, so you better appreciate it.

—Of course, I do, Bea— the young woman snickered. —Thank you…

—But you still pay this round.

—I will, I will— she confirmed, rolling her eyes.

A few weeks passed, Light Spinner returned to her routine, and the perks of her augmentations started to show. She was more efficient, recovered her faction reputation promptly, and earned money much faster than before.

Her ambition was paying off.

Yet that only made her want *more*.

So, one morning, as they lay in bed together, she woke up having dreamt she got a new installation.

The desire was messing with her head already.

The woman let out a long sigh, thinking about how it had barely been a month since they got back together, since she began removing her veil around Castaspella.

How would she take it?

And was she herself ready to give this up again? Having the young woman resting on her, half awake, with her soft hair sprawled over her chest?

She liked how this felt, but she certainly couldn't let it stop her now…

After a while of considering it, Light Spinner decided to tell her —I'm… eyeing a certain augmentation already.

Sleepy as she was, it took Castaspella a bit to process her words and reply; the woman caressing her hair was too distracting.

—You mean… that one that improves core effectiveness, right?

—Yes.

—When… will you buy it?— she then asked, interrupted by a yawn.

—Next week.

That finally made Castaspella perk up.

—*What*!?— she exclaimed, pushing herself up to look down at Light Spinner.

—I know it's just been a month and a half, but…

—Bea, why are you rushing? A whole year passed between your first and second augmentations, then only eight months before the third one. Now it won't even be two months!

—You heard Norwyn the other day! For all my augmentations, the effectiveness of my scripts is still too lacking! And that's because I've yet to improve my core processors!— the woman argued, annoyed.

—Why- Since *when* do you care about what *he* says!?

—Since I want his job, obviously…

—Bea— Castaspella interrupted her, serious. —You're supposed to do this for *yourself*.

—This *is* for me! I'm thinking about my future!

—Right… Of course.

The young woman took a deep breath with her eyes closed and said nothing else, seemingly resigned.

But that expression… it was unbearable for Light Spinner.

—I can… Um…— she hesitated, looking ashamed. —Why don't I wait until our ninth anniversary, then?

—You would?— Castaspella asked back, hopeful.

—Of course— she nodded, cupping her face. —A few months more won't make a difference, no?

The young woman chuckled and leant forward to kiss her briefly.

—Thank you.

—What about you? When will you install all those augments you've bought?

The question made her chuckle again and she pointed out —I only have three for now.

—That's a lot for me…

—Right— Castaspella snickered. —Answering your question, I just… want to do it all together after acquiring every augmentation I want from the factions I've been invited into!

—Right. Makes sense.

—Besides…— she then added, her face hovering over Light Spinner's. —One of us has to remember our time together, no?

—That's correct— the woman nodded, before meeting her lips for a moment. —I admit it's unfair that it always has to be you… but I can't do what you do. I can't… *wait* to get the perks of those augments; much less bear the increasing costs.

—I know, Bea— Castaspella promptly replied. —And that makes your gesture of waiting until our anniversary all the more significant— she assured her, smiling gently. —In any case, I am well aware of how… *strange* my decision is, but I'd rather grow enough money to face the costs than start over each time I buy one…

—Ah, yes, getting into those factions again would be a hassle, no?

—Precisely— she sighed, finally pushing herself to get up from bed. —Well, would you like some breakfast? I'm starving…

—Sure— Light Spinner accepted, sitting up. —But, speaking of factions… remind me: you have joined four up to now, right?

—That's correct— she nodded, while looking for a robe to put on. —And I have taken note of a few rumours that might get me into another three, at the very least.

—Already?

—Not right away. My skills aren't up to the task yet, but now I know what I need to work on — she explained, smiling cheerfully. —I would tell you about them, but it'd make no sense for you to join any other faction if you won't buy their augmentations…

—I'm still interested in knowing who you want to join— Light Spinner argued, stretching a bit as she stood up from bed. —Don't you want to tell me what you need to do to get into them? I might have some tips for you— she offered, smirking smugly.

—Fine— Castaspella chuckled. The woman followed her to the kitchen as she explained —The rumours I have collected are still encrypted, but I could make out the names: Salineas, Plumeria, and Bright Moon.

—Bright Moon? Isn't Micah a high-ranking member of Bright Moon?

—Yeah. But I'm far from being able to join.

—Requirements?— Light Spinner asked, while busying herself brewing some coffee.

—Installing a backdoor in their server, as per the usual, for which I need to crack their defenses and open *all* their ports— Castaspella began. —But the real issue is that their leader is possibly the most experienced hacker on Etheria…

—And surely the most uptight person and full of themselves— she mockingly commented. —What was their name?

—I- Well, I'm not supposed to know yet, that's encrypted information that I'm expected to learn only after I get into their server, but…

—But?

Hesitant, she revealed —I may have guessed who that is from Micah's rambles.

—What?— Light Spinner reacted, raising a brow in confusion. —Well, of course he knows, but why would he speak about them?

—He wasn't- I mean, actually, he was talking about someone else, but some things he said make me believe that's the Leader of Bright Moon— the young woman explained. As they both sat at the table with their breakfast, she elaborated —Basically, Micah has a habit of rambling about his wife, and keeps praising her non-stop, to the point I was sure he exaggerated a bit… Except that he can't be coming up with so many unbelievable feats, which made me pay more attention to the details.

—You can't possibly mean Angella is the leader of Bright Moon's faction— she scoffed, rolling her eyes.

—I'm pretty sure, Bea.

—Alright— she sighed, shaking her head. —She does fit the profile. What about the other factions?

—Similar requirements, but less complicated. I'm working on scripts that will let me handle it once my skill is up to it— Castaspella assured her. —They worked well with The Alliance, Kingdom of Snows, and Dryl.

—But Dryl is pretty much begging for anyone to join them— Light Spinner pointed out. —Entrapta has all ports open.

—Yes, and the lowest prices for augmentations because they are experimental, I know— she interrupted, nodding. —But I'm sure they'll be good to go by the time I buy those. I mean, with how cheap their original price is, I'm obviously leaving them for last.

—So you'll buy overpriced experimental augments?

—I insist: they should be tested enough by the time I get to them— the young woman repeated.

—You can be *very* stubborn, you know… It makes me think you'd even try to join every faction in Etheria if it weren't for the little cyber-war going on— Light Spinner laughed.

—I have little interest in Dark Edge, Fright Zone, or The Horde. So, even if I wasn't banned from joining them because I've joined The Alliance, I'd probably pass their invitations.

That made the woman shake her head in amusement as she started to eat her breakfast.

She had to admit, however, that she wasn't expecting that reply.

No interest? Not even with the powerful augmentations they might have?

She'll probably have to install everything to change factions, anyways, so it's pretty out of the question for Castaspella.

But all the talk about factions and the cyber-war made her realize —What if I ended up in an opposing faction, then?

—Huh?— the young woman let out, brow raised. —You mean, if you were to join one of those three next time?

—I'm not saying I will, of course. I know nothing about them… But, what if it happened? Would you be stubborn enough to seek me out regardless?

—Bea… I- Ye-yeah! I mean…

—Heh… I certainly hope you won't give up on me— Light Spinner interrupted, laughing breathlessly.

It took her a moment to reply, but Castaspella finally gave her a resolute look as she promised —I swear. I wouldn't *ever* give up on you.

Chapter End Notes

:D

If you have a bad feeling about next chapter… You're absolutely right. (>v<)

So, what do you think up to now?
And what theories do you have for the next 4 chapters?
Hehe…

See you next week!! (Or this weekend if you're also reading *The Tyrant of Mystacor*!)

Bye! Thanks for reading!!

Tenth Augmentation

Chapter Notes

Alright

Welcome back, please take a seat, and enjoy the ~~pain~~ chapter :D

It's a really angsty chapter, ngl, specially for Casta…
So, yes, expect it to hurt! <("^_^)

Aaaanyways, you're not here to read my notes, you're here for the new chapter!! So I hope you enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Eventually, it came to happen…

Castaspella had begged her to wait for her return before installing the new augmentation she got, the tenth one now. Yet *something* happened, and Light Spinner had it installed a day before she returned from a trip to the Kingdom of Snows' territory.

But, well, what was the worst that could happen?

She'd introduce herself a day later, yes, but it shouldn't make much of a difference, right?

After all, she'd have plenty of time to rebuild their relationship once Light Spinner rejoined Mystacor…

Right!?

How she wished that had been the case…

—What do you mean!? She wasn't- *Why* hasn't she been recruited!?

—Castaspella.

The leader of the faction, an old anthropomorphic ram, spoke her name in a tone that forced her to calm down.

He had already overlooked her storming into his office; he had to put a limit to this outburst.

—I'm sorry, Norwyn. I didn't mean to yell.

Yet he only sighed and calmly approached her.

—For starters… We have not recruited Light Spinner this time because she has already joined an enemy faction. The Horde. You might remember we investigated her for treason before, so this isn't unexpected— he began, greatly shocking the woman. —Second, I don't see why it would be of relevance. We have plenty of capable members…

—I'm- Excuse me, Sir, but… As we're affiliated with The Alliance's faction, and most of us are part of it too, that means we're *banned* from interacting with anyone in The Horde. But I can't- I mean, *how* could this happen!? Didn't my brother receive her after the last augmentation!?

—Yes, before she joined The Horde.

—Why would he let his Master join them!?

—It was not his prerogative, that's why— he quickly countered. —And his rank in The Alliance and Bright Moon's factions doesn't give him any authority within Mystacor.

—But, Sir…

—Enough, Castaspella— he interrupted her. —Why do you care? You now have her position, we don't need her… She only proved to be a traitor.

—She's not! And I just- I can't *not* interact with her!

—Why?

—Because she's my- Ugh… I'll tell you this in confidence, Norwyn, so that you understand, but… don't let it be public— she decided. Before speaking again, she rushed to the terminal on his desk and ran a few commands with great speed. He only sighed as the office shut closed, and all cameras turned off. —That should do— she muttered. —I wouldn't insist if this wasn't important to me, so I hope you'll understand, Sir. Light Spinner has been my-my partner for twelve years… Every time she installed an augmentation, we started over, of course, but-but it adds up to twelve years already— she messily blurted out.

There. She said it…

Now it made sense for him.

Pensive, he asked —And you believe it's worth it? The effort of getting her back into your life, over and over again, despite…

—Despite everything it entails, yes— she interrupted.

—Castaspella, you must understand I cannot allow you to meet her. It's not something I can control— Norwyn insisted. —I will overlook this conversation, won't put you under

vigilance despite what you have said, but unless you make sure to hide any evidence of it, I *will* have to report you if you're found interacting with her in any way.

—Thank you, Sir— she sighed, relieved. —One last question, though.

—Tell me.

—After her next augmentation, can she be recruited again?

—We can't look past what she has done… How will we know she won't betray us?

—I'm sure she only joined them for the augments they offer. I-I mean, they have exclusive ones that can't be found anywhere else— Castaspella argued.

—Ah…— he sighed. It was true. The woman was ambitious like that, indeed. After a long silence and serious pondering, he decided —Alright. We will allow her to return…

—Thank you, Norwyn.

—But, you better make sure she remains on our side going forward, or we'll have to limit her within our ranks.

—I will— she nodded.

—And restore my systems, will you?

—O-of course! Sorry.

A bit ashamed, Castaspella swiftly typed a series of commands on the terminal, all cameras blinked to life, and the office opened up again.

Not like she would have been able to leave, otherwise…

Encrypting a series of messages for Light Spinner, who now went by "Shadow Weaver" wasn't hard at all.

Finding and reaching her posed a challenge, yet nothing Castaspella couldn't manage.

But *getting a reply*?

Now that was turning into a nightmare.

The woman wouldn't answer, nor would she attend the meeting places Castaspella asked her to go to.

—That bitch…— she muttered, furiously typing on her terminal. —If *only* she had waited another day!

Castaspella felt herself closer and closer to doing something completely unethical…

A month had passed, so she struggled to resist the temptation of "breaking" into *Shadow Weaver's* place, as her biometrics were still on the system.

But she had to try again first.

She sent one last invitation, to meet at their favourite ramen shop this time, and hoped for the best.

When the time came, Castaspella made her way to the restaurant, acting as inconspicuous as possible since she felt observed, and ordered her usual dish.

Then, the waiting game began…

Would she show up this time?

What would she do if she didn't?

Could she really break into her house?

Or rather, not *break* but- No! Even if she has the credentials to enter, it'd be an invasion of her privacy!

Castaspella may know her, but *Shadow Weaver* does not!

—Good evening. What would you like to order?— a waiter asked behind her, probably to the person in the other booth.

—I'll have some… Hiyashi Chuka? Did I say that right?

—Of course. Right away.

Was that her!?

Sure it was!

Her voice, and the order…

—You came— Castaspella uttered, breathless.

She was there.

Right behind her.

They were sitting back to back.

The closest they had been in a month…

—Why are you so insistently contacting me?

—Why were you ignoring me!?

—There's a cyber-war between our factions, *genius*.

—I know, that's why I'm trying to be discreet…

—That only tells me you're not a complete fool— the woman replied.

Castaspella could *imagine* how she must have rolled her eyes.

—Listen, I… knew you before your last augmentation. And… you weren't supposed to join The Horde.

—You say you know me?

—And pretty well, yes.

—If that's the case, you must already know I wouldn't let anyone dictate what I do.

—Bea…

—It's "Shadow Weaver"— she quickly countered.

—Is that why you weren't answering? Because I called you "Light Spinner" or "Beatrix"?

—Perhaps.

—You can't have thought I got the wrong person! Your names are on your notes, and my brother welcomed you like always!

—*I don't know you*. Using such names made you suspicious— the woman clarified.

—You've been spying on me instead of meeting me…— she realized.

—Precisely.

—Then why come now?

—This place— Shadow Weaver finally admitted. —I have receipts of this place, all of them for orders of Shio ramen and Hiyashi Chuka ramen— she explained. —The invitation to this place, and the "codes" being these orders made me curious.

—I hoped they would. It was my last attempt— Castaspella admitted.

—*Who* are you?

—You can't remember me because we- Ah… I'm Micah's sister— she slowly began. —This is the tenth time I'm doing this, so I'll answer some of the questions I *know* you have. First, I am not in your notes, despite the relationship we had, because we decided so. Second, said relationship is… *was* romantic; with brief intermissions after each installation, it adds up to twelve years.

—*What*!?

—But, as we decided to hide it from Micah, and basically everyone, the plan has always been that I tell you all of this after he welcomes you— Castaspella went on. —Last time, however, I was on a trip when you performed the installation. I arrived a day later, only to be told you had been recruited by The Horde…

—So you could never tell me all of this…

—Exactly.

After a moment of silence, she hesitantly asked —Have I… always returned to you?

—It takes you some time and getting to know me, but you always have, yes. However, once or twice you've admitted to having fallen for me within hours, which was very adorable and quite unbelievable— the young woman laughed.

—I find that hard to believe…

—I wouldn't believe it myself if I hadn't heard it from you— she admitted with half a smile. Hearing the waiter arrive with Shadow Weaver's order, she paused and waited for him to leave before adding —But I have another proof of our relationship. One that… may finally convince you.

—Really?— she asked back, sounding incredulous. —You have one chance, then. If not, forget about contacting me ever again.

—Deal— Castaspella accepted.

—Tell me.

—You have a locked box in your bedroom, right? It isn't digital; it's old, uses an actual bronze key.

—I've opened it, yes. Out of curiosity, since there's nothing about the contents in my notes, only a comment about it being my most important possession. The receipts from here were inside— Shadow Weaver admitted. —What with it? Is your "proof" among the contents? Or is knowing about it your so-called proof?

—There's… a ring in there too, right?

Silence.

Perhaps she had guessed it already?

In any case, Castaspella preferred to wait for an answer.

—Correct. What does that mean?

There goes…

Extending her hand out of the booth, the young woman told her —Turn a bit to look at this.

Silence again.

For a brief moment that felt eternal, neither said a thing.

—Does that mean what I'm thinking?

—You… proposed to me about a week before your last installation— she finally revealed, sorrow tainting her voice.

—So I'm that cruel, huh?

—You said- You *promised* it wouldn't be just a ring.

—I'm nowhere near done with augmentations— Shadow Weaver severely said. —Proposing to you was *not* a smart move, nor was it "romantic". Aren't you *suffering* right now?

—O-only because I couldn't- Ah… Never mind…— Castaspella sighed, surrendered. —I would say you regret what you did, but you don't even remember. So, I don't think- I shouldn't have… done this.

Was she… *giving up*!?

—All this effort and you'll leave now?

—Yes— she replied, standing up from the booth to go pay the bill.

The old woman stared at her ramen, baffled.

So she just…

After twelve years and this last month, she was *really* giving up!?

She couldn't believe it until she saw her leave the restaurant.

—I'm starting to see why I proposed to that woman…— she chuckled. Shaking her head, she sighed —I'm insane, am I not?

Well, good thing she still had to eat her soup.

She'd need some time to ponder…

The moment Castaspella arrived home, she fell to her knees and let out a drowned whimper. Covering her mouth, she tried to hold back her tears, yet couldn't…

Should she give up?

Was that it?

Maybe she could wait until she installed her next augmentation, but… there wasn't even any guarantee that the woman would seek out Micah's help again.

So *how*!?

Her hands were shaking when she finally released her mouth, and her sight immediately fixed on the ring…

It should mean something.

It *had* to mean something.

It was a promise, was it not?

But how to hold the woman to it, when she couldn't even remember making it?

She simply couldn't…

And yet, she didn't have the heart to just let go.

Part of her refused to surrender, even if logic told her there was no point in continuing with what's essentially a cyclic torture.

But her stubborn heart does not care about logic…

However, she had no strength left in her now; she needed to rest, recover, perhaps cry a bit more.

She did, in fact, cry herself to sleep, and only woke up when a message arrived to her terminal.

Despite it being *very* early in the morning, she still got up to check what it was.

—It better not be Norwyn at this time or I'll…— she began muttering, yet her threat died in her mouth as she saw the sender's name. —She… Why would she…

Shadow Weaver had sent her a message.

After a month of never replying, after that failure of a meeting…

Fully awake now, Castaspella opened the message and a gasp escaped her.

> What do The Horde and The Alliance have in common?
>
> Answer correctly to win next round.

"Win next round" could only mean one thing…

But…

She couldn't have remembered, so how did she know that's how they referred to paying for the ramen?

The young woman shook her head, brushing the question aside, and focused on the riddle.

What could it mean?

What do these two factions have in common if they are on opposite sides of the war!?

She had to think…

It would perhaps be her only chance to meet her again.

She had to think a lot… but not like herself.

She had to think *like Beatrix*.

After a few hours pondering the matter, she finally decided to answer.

Uptight leaders full of themselves.

She had once referred to the leader of The Alliance as "uptight and full of themselves". She probably didn't remember saying it, but it was obviously her personal opinion, so it was natural for her to maintain it…

After hitting "send", she impatiently waited for the reply, staring at her terminal while fiddling with her hair.

Fortunately, it only took her a while to answer.

When the neon lights shine brighter and the moon can't be seen.

"The neon lights shine brighter" had to mean at night.

But that thing about the moon…

Castaspella felt at a loss for a moment, until an idea occurred to her, and she immediately went to check the lunar calendar.

What a smart way of hiding the meaning of the message. The new moon; it would be at the end of the week.

But… why was she sending coded messages instead of encrypting straightforward text?

—Call me old-fashioned, but I prefer coded language over encrypted messages— the woman explained.

—I can't believe it… And then you make fun of me for being polite to artificial intelligence software!

—I do?— she chuckled.

—Yes. Always— she grunted, rolling her eyes.

—Sounds like me— the old woman smirked.

They had met as arranged, and it surprised Castaspella that she wasn't using her veil now. There was only a mask sitting on the table next to her, which she presumed must be hers, yet she preferred not to bring that up…

They were finally having this conversation; that's all that mattered.

However, this time, Shadow Weaver had challenged Castaspella to sit next to her instead of in the booth behind hers.

It was dangerous, yet she insisted: If she really meant to bring the woman back into her life, she had to be willing to take some risks.

—But, back to the matter at hand, it can be obvious to someone smart enough. If those messages got intercepted…

—We're not under vigilance, I already checked. So there's no reason for anyone to intercept our messages— she cut her, casually stirring her bowl of ramen. —However, if I had sent encrypted messages, *that* would have been suspicious for my faction.

—Oh. I hadn't thought about that— Castaspella admitted. —Well but, why this now? What if someone…

—Sees us sitting together? Same as before. We're not being followed or watched. The people of this place are unlikely to rat you out seeing how friendly they are with you, and as long as we don't make a scandal, we should pass unnoticed— Shadow Weaver dismissed her.

—Alright. So… why did you decide to contact me after what happened the last time?

—You left abruptly. Gave me no chance to argue my point.

—About you being cruel? I don't want to hear it— the young woman scoffed.

—You have to accept it: I shouldn't have proposed to you. It was stupid…

—I don't think it was!— Castaspella hissed, barely able to keep herself from yelling. —It meant a lot to me!

—I gave you hope and then basically betrayed you— she argued. —Why would I install the augment a day before your return, if not to keep you from finding me in time?

—That's what I don't know!

—Well, I do. I did it on purpose— Shadow Weaver assured her.

—No.

—I did— she insisted, setting down her chopsticks and facing Castaspella.

—The woman I knew would *never* do that to me. *You* might be treacherous, but that's the persona you've chosen to be *now*!— she countered, putting down her chopsticks too. Moving closer, she angrily muttered —And I refuse to believe the Beatrix I know is no longer there.

—Face it: she's not.

—I don't believe it.

—I don't give a damn what you believe— the old woman spat, leaning forward trying to intimidate her.

—You obviously do.

—Whatever makes you think that?

—We wouldn't be having this argument otherwise!— Castaspella insisted, still muttering albeit a bit louder, feeling her heart racing due to their proximity.

She was dying to kiss her… It was making her breathless.

—You're so stubborn and naïve…— Shadow Weaver mocked her, smirking. —It makes me curious why I spent twelve years with you.

—*Fuck you*— she scoffed, finally reaching her limit. Unable to hold back anymore, she grabbed the old woman by the collar and pulled her into a harsh kiss, which she didn't hesitate to return. Sliding closer, Castaspella barely kept herself from sitting on her lap, yet her hands quickly moved down to Shadow Weaver's waist and brushed downwards. It would have been so easy for them to fall into the passion of the moment, but the young woman suddenly remembered their current status as members of opposite factions, and retreated with a jolt. —No! No… That's- We… *can't*— she breathed out.

—So you get touchy all of a sudden and now leave me hanging?— Shadow Weaver complained, frowning.

—I-I shouldn't have. Even if we were a couple, that was… incorrect.

—You can be so ridiculous…

—And you can be very mean.

—*That* just now was "mean". What am I supposed to do with the arousal you caused now?

—Sorry, but… it-it's not even the right place!

—Let me guess: And we can't go to your place or mine because you're afraid we'll "be seen"?

—Yes…— Castaspella sighed, returning to her ramen.

—I would say "fuck me, I guess", but you're clearly a coward.

—We shouldn't get into trouble with our factions— she insisted. —I just… can't get you back this time. Until your next augmentation, I'll have to accept we can only meet in secret and remain as inconspicuous as possible.

—Then why did you seek me out?

—I just wanted to- I hoped to convince you to return to Mystacor for next time… If you're welcomed by my brother again, and let *us* recruit you, if you stick to Mystacor from then on, we can return to…

—To?

—To being a couple again. At least for some time between your augmentations.

Castaspella let out a long sigh and continued to eat her ramen, which had already gone cold.

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver stared at hers, thoughtful, then slurped the last noodles before speaking again.

—I knew I shouldn't join *the* faction with the most enemies. Micah told me to stick to Mystacor too, but… I wanted to piss them off— she admitted. —I wasn't lying before. I *did* purposely install the augment a day before your return. My notes said I wanted to get back at Norwyn, for which I had decided to join The Horde this time…

—I… You mean because they accused you of being a traitor— Castaspella nodded.

—So a traitor I shall be.

—It was a stupid mistake they made, they regret it, and I told Norwyn that you must have done it for the augmentations they offer. But you shouldn't have- I mean, you joining The Horde made things more difficult for me; convincing Norwyn to let you return next time was… a real hassle, but I did.

—Why?

—Because it's the only way I'd be allowed to be with you, even if not publicly as partners…

—So you've made sure they will take me back after the next augmentation?

—Yes— she nodded, looking back at Shadow Weaver with pleading eyes.

—How did you manage?

—I had to… tell him- tell Norwyn the truth— she sighed, looking down.

—You took a great risk— the woman pointed out.

—It’s what you wanted me to do tonight, isn’t it?

Silence.

She didn’t reply. Instead, she grabbed her bowl to drink the remaining soup.

Only once she settled it back on the table, now empty, did she answer —I wanted to confirm I didn’t make a mistake by proposing to you.

Shadow Weaver looked back at her with a smirk and grabbed her chin to tilt her head up a bit.

—And?

—It wasn’t a mistake… just a bit unwise— she uttered. —So you’ll be glad to know I’ll be installing The Horde’s exclusive augmentation soon.

—You will?

—Care to join me for one last meal before I do?

—Please…

—Good— the woman grinned, leaning forward to kiss her.

Chapter End Notes

> You know, originally, LS was supposed to get scars from a faulty augment that would "corrupt" her skin and such… The most logical idea would have been that The Horde's augment did that, but she only appears as SW in this chapter and only during this period she joined them, so it would have meant the "corruption" happened after the installation and when she's no longer part of The Horde.
>
> So, yeah, I discarded the idea of the scars, after all, but I decided to keep the mask thing, at least for this chapter. Again, it won't be appearing anymore either.
>
> Well! I hope you liked the chapter! See you next week!! :D

Fifteenth Augmentation

Chapter Notes

Welcome back to… another low-key heartbreaking chapter <("^_^)

It is very late, I wanna go to sleep but, first, I wanted to post this lol

So, yeah, I don't know what to say in this note, perhaps I should have left it empty ehe

Anyways: please, enjoy today's chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

For the few augmentations that followed, five in three and a half years, things returned to "normal" for the women. They fell back into the routine of secretly getting together, starting with a meal, Light Spinner getting to know her, and hearing about their shared life.

It would soon be sixteen years… and almost four years of engagement.

So now, after going through the whole "circus" once more, they decided to go to Light Spinner's place.

—…And that's basically why we call it "a round"; it was pretty useful when you had joined The Horde— Castaspella chuckled.

—Well, next round is on me, then.

—You're already inviting me to eat out again?— she asked, raising a brow with a smirk.

—Obviously— the woman replied, rolling her eyes, right as they arrived at her place. —You still want to come in, don't you?

—Please.

—Hmm… you're in the system, that's good— she noticed, letting her walk in before her, and promptly locking the door once inside. —So… I've forgotten you fifteen times already, yet never deleted you from my system?

—No one realizes I have access to your place, or you to mine, unless they specifically look for it— Castaspella explained. —So, many times, even *you* had no idea I could access…

—Have you ever…

—Broken into this place? No…— she interrupted. —I considered it when you joined The Horde, but… I didn't want to invade your privacy like that.

—It wouldn't be "breaking in" when you have the "keys"…

—It would still be an invasion of your privacy— Castaspella insisted, taking a seat in front of the table.

—Coffee?

—Please.

—So, tell me more about yourself…

The women kept talking late into the night.

Castaspella told her a dozen anecdotes about them both, things they did together, shenanigans of their crusade to keep the secret, and a bit of their arguments too.

—I mean… all couples have disagreements, it's normal and healthy— the young woman argued. —It lets us better know each other, understand each other, and reach consensus.

—But, for that, both parts would need to remember the argument and consensus reached…

—Yeah— Castaspella sighed. —That's why I try to tell you about them…

There was a moment of silence after that, in which Light Spinner stood up and considered her next words.

—Casta… You look tired— she pointed out, removing the empty mugs from the table. —And I don't mean "sleepy"…

—I think- I mean, I am a bit… tired, emotionally. I feel drained, I won't… lie— she began, looking away. Her eyes became suddenly teary, it stung and made her gasp as she attempted to hold back a sob. But, much as she tried, she couldn't keep her tears from falling. —I'm sorry, I didn't mean to cry… but I'm just- It's so difficult! Losing you over and over again!— she finally sobbed, covering her mouth.

—Hey, hey…— Light Spinner gently let out, standing to approach her. —Ah… Casta, why do you keep doing this if it's hurting you so much?

—Be-because I don't want to give up on you- *us*!— she cried.

—So you're willing to keep suffering…— she sighed, kneeling next to her. She then cupped her face, slowly made her look back, and reminded her —Augmenting is the name of the game in this society. I can't stop for you; if I did, I'd resent you for the rest of my life… and I don't want that.

—But…

—Listen: I can see why I fell for you so many times, and now… I think I also understand the only couple of notes I have about you.

—What do you mean?

—My augmentations don't just enhance me; they allow me to better protect you while you gather augments…

—What are you… talking about? What… does that mean?— Castaspella asked, confused, interrupting herself every time she sniffed.

—I've found notes that speak about never letting anything happen to "her", using my improved abilities to keep "her" from harm's way… And I can say for sure now that those talk about *you*.

—But… nothing threatens me other than… I don't know, *myself*…

—Perhaps there's something I've learnt but have never… written down— Light Spinner suggested. —Ah… but it doesn't matter. Even if those notes made no sense, what's important it's what I said before: If I stop installing augmentations, not because I'm done and satisfied, but because *you* need me to stop, I'll only resent you…

Castaspella leant against the woman's hand, eyes closed as she held back more tears. Eventually, she nodded, face contorted in sorrow, realizing that was true.

—I don't want you to resent me… I don't want to stop you… But I… am so… *tired*…

—Perhaps you *should* let go, Casta.

—I can't- No. I don't *want to*! I-I love you, Bea! *Please*!— Castaspella sobbed, eyes tightly closed.

—Look at me. Hey… look at me— she called, now cupping the young woman's face. —You are leaving your life in this. You're… forty-four years *old*, Casta. Can you say for sure that the last sixteen years haven't been a waste of time and energy?

—They have not! I did *not* "waste" time! Or energy! I did it all for you, and you're here! Even when I thought I lost you to The Horde, you returned!— she argued, raising her voice.

—All this time invested on this Sisyphean quest… what has it given you in return besides pain and suffering?— Light Spinner insisted, holding Castaspella's face between her hands. —I don't understand how I could ever claim to love you if I allow you to do this…

—I don't understand why you would want me to give up, Bea…

—I just want you to be *happy*, Casta.

—But…

—Don’t say you can’t be happy without me— she interrupted. —You can. You *should be*.

—Well, I don’t want to!— the young woman countered, placing her hands over Light Spinner’s, keeping them around her face as she caressed them. —I want to be happy *with you*. I don’t think I can be happy without you in my life, not fully… I’ll always love you, Bea…

—Casta…

—But if you don’t want me, I’ll just leave. You only have to *say it*— Castaspella finally accepted, dropping her hands.

—Wait, no.

Both women stood up one after the other, Light Spinner immediately getting in her way to block the door.

—You don’t have to pretend…

—I am *not*. I don’t want you to leave, Casta. *Listen* to me. I-I’m trying to…

—To what? “Gently” break my heart? Bea, I love you, but you *suck* at being gentle on purpose…

—No, that’s not what I meant— she immediately denied, shaking her head and hands, disgruntled. —Ugh, you’re *so* stubborn… Why are you doing this?

—I’ve told you already! Because I love you! Because I’ll *never* forget you! And because this *thing* means something to me!— she replied, showing her the ring. —It was supposed to mean something to you too!

—I know, I *know*, but… Ah… Just look at you— Light Spinner sighed, cupping her face again with one hand and gently stroking Castaspella’s cheek with her thumb. —My augmentations let me notice more of your vitals than normal, so I know you are sleep-deprived, chronically stressed and anxious, depressed even… You’re *far* from being happy.

—I am happy when you’re with me… It’s in these moments after each of your augments that I suffer, I won’t pretend I don’t… But for me, it’s worth it. For you.

—Don’t you think you deserve *better*, something more… stable? More dependable?

—I don’t care about dependability or stability! Beatrix! Why is it so difficult for you to understand that I just want to be with whom I love, who *happens to be you*!?

—Casta!— Light Spinner reacted, once again catching Castaspella’s face between her hands. —This is ridiculous… You have to- Uh…— she began saying, until something made her interrupt herself and look away. Her ears twitched for a moment while the young woman wondered what was going on. The next second, they finally stopped, and her eyes blinked with a bright neon green light. —You said my biometrics are registered in your place, right?

—Yes?

—That explains it. Someone's breaking into your home— she explained, looking back and letting go of her. —I've already called security, but… if you want to go to make sure they didn't take anything…

—Wait, wait. What do you mean- How do you know someone's breaking into my- Oh… Your augmentations!?

—Yes.

—I should… go check my things… yes…— she nodded, looking down.

—Go then…— Light Spinner sighed, moving away from the door.

—Is the offer for the next round still up?— Castaspella shyly asked, right before stepping through the frame.

—Absolutely.

—When?

—Tomorrow night?

—I'd like that, yes— she accepted with a smile. —Good night. And thanks for… the help. See you tomorrow…

When the young woman arrived home, she was immediately questioned by a couple of officers. After half an hour of interrogation and proving ownership of the place, she was allowed to check whether anything had been stolen or broken, only to find her terminal had been hacked into, yet no files had been copied or compromised.

The only action taken, according to the logs, was a massive search of a few keywords through her documents that never finished. Whoever had broken into her apartment seemed to be looking for files where faction names were mentioned, along with Beatrix's names: "Light Spinner" or "Shadow Weaver".

Did that mean someone was trying to steal information about the woman through her!?

This was terrible! And once the leaders of her factions learnt of this, they would freak out over possibly having a breach!

She may have no sensible information about them, and most of her files are encrypted regardless of their contents, but they would probably *not* care in the slightest.

Was she… becoming the weakest link?

Was that why Light Spinner had notes about protecting her while she gathers augmentations?

She still had another twenty-five augments to buy before she could install them, but the prices made it impossible to get them faster than one every month… or two months, to round it up.

According to her calculations, that meant she'd need another four years to get them all and finally be ready to install them; four years and she'd be in a position to forfeit all her factions' reputation, her remaining money, her active scripts, and of course, her memory…

So, perhaps, she had to talk with Light Spinner and make a deal.

The following evening, as promised, the old woman invited Castaspella to dinner.

Sitting side by side in a booth, they ordered their usual ramen, then chatted about irrelevant matters for a while…

When their food finally arrived, it was time for the *big revelations*.

—So, will you tell me what's going on? You're keeping eye-contact to the minimum.

—I have- Um, I just want to… ah… make a deal— Castaspella hesitantly said, sighing deeply. —It would seem your notes are right: you have to protect me or whatever, most likely because my lack of installed augmentations combined with the positions I hold in my factions turns me into the perfect target for enemy factions to steal information from… And for *your* enemies to do as much— she began explaining. Despite wanting to say something, Light Spinner remained speechless, so she went on —It is clear I should install my augments as soon as possible, but I am in seven factions and refuse to lose my reputation and rank until I have acquired all their available augmentations. So…

—How long?

—Patience, I was just about to explain.

—Right.

—So, I made the calculations and the fastest I can get the remaining twenty-five augments… would be *four* years, approximately— she concluded. —Now, here's my proposal…

—Wait, wait… That's a *lot* of time.

—I know, it really is, which is why I want to ask you to keep me safe, as your notes say, for the next four years, and as soon- I *swear*, *as soon* as I get the last augment, I'll install everything.

—And then will focus on *yourself*?

—I will— she nodded, resolute.

—Deal— Light Spinner accepted, offering her hand to shake. She then pulled her closer and whispered —I won't stop you from seducing me again and again, *but* I exhort you to refrain from aiming for anything more than an affair.

—I… understand— Castaspella sighed, looking down.

—Don't look so dejected… Think about it as a less serious version of what you've been doing. You don't need me to fall in love with you to *be* with me. Why put so much effort into something that may not last more than a month?

—A month… so you'll be buying monthly augmentations too?

—Perhaps…— Light Spinner admitted, rolling her eyes. —Like you, I have another twenty-something augments to buy, and my calculations estimate about the same time as you, with a minimum of one month, and a maximum of two months between each purchase.

—So you'd be installing them more frequently… Yeah, it'd be a waste of effort to have you fall for me if you'd forget me again so quickly— Castaspella had to admit.

—From my notes, I know I've been wanting to do so for years now, but once again had annotations saying "Give *her* some time" and "You'll know who *she* is". All very ominous but clear enough once I met you— she explained. —So, since we've made this deal, I will now update my notes…

As she said that, the woman took out something the size of a notebook, an electronic touchscreen, and immediately typed a few commands to decrypt, open, edit, close, and encrypt her welcome-notes file.

—You still have that?

—Why wouldn't I?

—I thought… with your augments, you'd need something more up-to-date, compatible with them— Castaspella shyly replied.

—Call me old-fashioned, but as long as this works and remains reliable, I'm not changing it for anything…

—I'm glad— she giggled.

—Why?— Light Spinner asked, suspicious.

—I gifted it to you like… ten years ago— she explained, looking away.

—You- That makes so much sense…

—Do-does it?

—Never mind. Back to the deal: you better keep your end of it.

—I will; I wouldn’t betray you— Castaspella assured her, albeit unable to hide her sadness.

—Don’t make that face…— Light Spinner promptly told her, reaching for her chin to tilt her face up. —Look at me: be a bit more selfish.

—For me, that means making sure I never lose you…

—*Wrong*. When I tell you to be more selfish, I mean you must focus on yourself, your needs and wishes.

—But you don’t seem to understand my deepest wish is to have you in my life!

—Casta…

—I know, I know. Regardless, the deal is done, so… I’ll stick to the plan: buy the augments, install them as soon as I have them all, and… keep it simple with you, I guess— the young woman accepted.

Chapter End Notes

And that was it for now!!
Just two more chapters to go XD

I'll say it now: the last chapter is SO LONG I'm so sorry <("^_^)
But I promise it's good hehe

And, ofc, next chapter is gonna hurt even more (/v\) Sorry ksjssj

So! Thank you all for reading!! See you next week!!

Far Too Many Augmentations

Chapter Notes

Alright so…
Welcome back!

I'm sorry to say this chapter is kinda short.
It's, however, pretty important…
More like VERY important.
Also quite sad, be warned…

However, I shall compensate with a lengthy final chapter! XD

In any case, please enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As usual, Light Spinner installed another augmentation that month, resetting her memories yet again…

But now, it would soon be four years since their deal, and Castaspella found herself hesitant to buy the fortieth augment.

More than twenty times in the past years, she had started affairs with the old woman and, every single time, she had reminded her of their deal, albeit with more and more reticence. She considered many times the possibility of going back on her word, pretending the deal never happened… but she *couldn't*.

She wouldn't betray her like that.

However, as more and more resets happened, Castaspella grew bitter. She loved Light Spinner too much, yet she was sick of going through the same pain, so many times, and so frequently now.

Perhaps she would have ignored the deal this time, perhaps nothing would have convinced her to install her *many* augmentations either… but time and relentlessness will wear down even the most obstinate mindsets.

So, this time, after their final farewell, Castaspella returned home almost in automatic and, as soon as the door closed behind her, she *collapsed*.

Feeling defeated, devoid of strength, and unable to hold back her tears, she made no effort to move from the spot where she fell to the ground and allowed herself to let it all out.

Looking at her ring only made things worse, and part of her wanted to throw it away, while another part refused to take it off at all.

Did it mean something?

In this world, so full of technology, could such a small thing as a ring mean anything?

Could *feelings* mean anything?

Should they?

After a few hours, the young woman managed to drag herself to the bathroom, get cleaned, and eventually convinced herself to have something to eat before going to sleep.

Yet she could hardly munch a bit of rice before feeling sick again, so she gave up and went to lay down.

Staring at the ceiling, her mind went over their life together, since meeting Light Spinner until the first time she installed an augment. And then… then it felt like everything from then on was nothing but an illusion.

And it… kind of *was*.

Thinking about it, Castaspella felt a bitter taste in her mouth as she realized all those memories, all those moments that were supposed to be shared… now existed only in her mind.

Could it be said all of that happened?

How would those *memories* be any different from mere *imagination*?

And, in that case, what about the proposal?

Was it real?

Was the ring enough proof of it?

How could it be different from any random ring?

Did the Light Spinner who proposed to her still exist?

Thirteen years of struggle to continue their relationship… eight years of so-called "engagement"…

Did they mean anything if no one but Castaspella retained the memories of them?

For such a long time the young woman had been putting so much effort into their relationship, while Light Spinner only focused on installing those augmentations, never sparing a thought for all that had to be sacrificed…

Perhaps… she was right.

Maybe Castaspella had to be more selfish, in a way that solely focused on herself.

And, probably, the first step would be… to forget.

A message arrived at Micah's portable terminal right as he finished welcoming Light Spinner. Normally, he would have ignored it and leave it for later, yet he had an odd feeling and decided to check it right away.

—Hmm, Casta?

His sister had sent him an encrypted file with a message and a decryption key.

—Who?

—Sorry, Light Spinner. My sister just messaged me and it looks important.

—You have a sister?

—Yes! I don't usually mention her, but yeah.

—I suppose you have nothing else to do, so you can take care of that— the old woman pointed out.

—Thank you very much— he gratefully replied. —Ah, but before I forget: The health report should be ready soon, and…

—And?

—It's important that you read it before deciding on your next augmentation. That's all.

—Fine, then. I shall wait for it.

—Good. I'll get going— he farewelled.

Micah arrived at his sister's place soon enough. Having read her message and the encrypted file, he knew he couldn't waste a second.

She was finally installing her augmentations!

A team of technicians was just leaving the apartment, which meant he was right on time.

—Are you in charge of welcoming her?— one of them asked.

—Yes, I'm her brother.

—Alright. Be careful. We just installed forty augments, some of them experimental. Handle her with care.

—Of course— Micah immediately nodded. —Oh-oh, one more thing: did you order a health report for her? I mean, between her age, being just human, and the large number of augmentations installed in one go…

—We did. It's mandatory in these cases. It should be ready this week.

—Perfect, thank you— he nodded.

Without losing any more time, he finally walked into the apartment and closed the door. Carefully, he made his way into her room, where she lay in bed, still unconscious.

After so many years, he never thought this day would come…

So he took a seat on a couch in the corner, and patiently waited for her to show any signs of waking up…

—Ugh…— she eventually groaned, starting to move her fingers.

The woman felt… numb.

Silence and darkness surrounded her…

Then, a light.

As her vision adjusted, the ceiling came into view and, along with it, an influx of metadata flooded her mind.

Afterwards, her hearing gradually started working, and even more metadata swamped her, causing the information to be unintelligible for a moment.

—Hey, Sis— Micah gently called, approaching her side. —Welcome back, Casta.

—What?— she groggily muttered, confused despite perfectly understanding his words.

—Take it easy— he told her, placing a hand on her shoulder to keep her from trying to sit up. —Your name is Castaspella. I'm your brother, Micah— he began. —You just went through a process called installation, and a number of augmentations now enhance you. Likely, that means you're now overwhelmed by too many stimuli, so better lay down until you are stable enough.

—I have- I feel- There's so, *so* much information— she managed to say.

—You'll get used to it soon enough, Sis, don't worry— he assured her, frowning in concern. —Would you like to wait a bit more before I introduce you to yourself?

—No, it-it's alright…

—Fine. I'll open the file, and we can begin— he nodded, taking out his portable terminal. —I barely skimmed over it on the way here, but I understand this is mostly a summary of core memories for you. Except… for the final note. It's more like, a message to you from yourself, so once we're done, I'll give it to you to read, alright?

—Yeah, that's okay.

After about an hour or so, Castaspella was starting to feel much better, more stable, far less overwhelmed, and now had a better understanding of who she was.

And so, it was time to read that note.

—I'll leave now, it's getting late and I think it's better to give you some privacy for that, but call me if you need anything, Sis.

—I will. Thank you.

—Bye…

Once Micah left, the woman took a deep breath and slowly exhaled.

A note to herself… What could it be about?

Only one way to find out…

> This is a note to myself, from a version of me that will die the moment the installation begins. I have made sure to record everything relevant to me in this file, especially the things that make me who I am, but I have left out something very important. After so many years, I'm finally letting go of it, regardless of how significant it is to me, in hopes that the new me will be happier. For that, much as it pains me, I have to forget *her*. As her only focus is set on enhancements, on installing as many augmentations as possible, the time has come for me to live my life and let her reset her memories without worrying about losing her.
>
> If I don't remember her and the time spent together, there will finally be no suffering for me. I give up. Just as she wanted. And most importantly, I'm doing this now that she's installing a new augment, because I don't want her to remember me either; she won't know about our deal and, hopefully, will never realize that the vague notes that she has speak about me.
>
> We'll go our separate ways, the only remaining evidence of us, of all those years, now hidden and soon forgotten by me too. So I can only end this message saying: *do not seek her out*. Never again. Because, with each reset, I died a little, and I'm sure she won't stop any time soon… Her thirst for power far surpasses whatever love she may have ever felt for me.

P.S.: You'll probably also read this, Micah, so, first, I apologize for not telling you. And second, please don't try to find out who she is, that's all I'll ask of you.

—"The time spent together", "Years", a-and "Love she may have ever felt for me"!? I had… a partner!? Why would I- Why write this note if I didn't want to remember her!? And… Micah didn't know? Was it a secret!?— Castaspella began wondering, thinking aloud as her mind spiraled into confusion that threatened to turn into anxiety. —I don't understand…

A few days went by before Light Spinner finally received her health report.

And what it said…

—How can they- Because I'm sixty-three!? My species is long-lived! They can't judge me by human standards!— she indignantly cried out, gripping the edges of her terminal. The result was far from what she expected, and she refused to acknowledge it! But these reports weren't mere "suggestions". As per Etheria's laws, mandatory for all individuals, regardless of faction, their conclusions were *final*. Which could only mean one thing… —No, no!— she seethed, before her anger was replaced by utter defeat. She pushed herself away from the terminal, resisting the urge to punch the screen, stalked into the kitchen and flopped down on a chair. Resting against the backrest, with her head hanging back, she stared at the ceiling, feeling numb. —I am not… allowed to install any more augments… ever again.

Chapter End Notes

<("^-^)
That was so cruel of me, I know…

I'm so sorry (/-\)

And now I can't wait to post the final chapter! XD

Hehe, so, see you next week!!

Starting Over

Chapter Notes

We're at the end, my dear readers!

So welcome back and I hope you'll enjoy this ending! :D

I don't have much to say this time, just... well, I'm on vacation with my friends, we just got tattooed today, and I'm posting this while snacking some food at midnight (/v\)

XD We're actually playing smash or pass with the D&D Monster Manual! So I'll bid you farewell for now XD

Please enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Castaspella was sitting in front of her home terminal, munching on roasted seaweed snacks while going through some documents.

Paperwork had become a nightmare since her promotion within Mystacor's faction…

She was absolutely not expecting it, especially after barely two months since her return following her augmentations, but the circumstances so demanded it.

Apparently, the only two candidates to take Norwyn's place were her and another woman who had installed an augmentation at the same time as her, which meant they should have been evenly matched to be promoted. However, Castaspella's experimental augmentations from Dryl provided her with such a reputation boost, that she became *the* most qualified candidate.

So now, here she was: dealing with endless administrative files…

She was close to falling asleep on her terminal when one of her augments, integrated with an intrusion detection system, warned her about the presence of a sniffer scanning her network.

She had a spy!?

Well, whoever the intruder was, they seemingly became aware they had been discovered, since the system soon lost track of them.

Odd…

A spy skilled enough to realize they've been discovered and disappear like that… They clearly underestimated Castaspella initially, didn't they?

Part of her felt a bit smug for scaring them off so easily, but another part remained wary… What if they returned?

Perhaps she could find traces of them: an IP address, an unfiltered open port they may have sneaked in through, or a backdoor they may have installed; just *something* that might let her do a bit of footprinting…

As the new Head of Mystacor, she couldn't let this slide.

—Damn her!

Light Spinner almost threw her terminal away from anger.

She couldn't believe how easily she had been discovered.

Seething, she began walking up and down the room…

—Um, excuse me— a voice called from outside, after knocking a few times. —Excuse me, Master. Did you call?

—You're late, Micah— she reproached him, opening the door.

—Late for what?— he inquired, confused as she hadn't expressed any urgency when calling him. However, before she could answer, his attention was drawn to her terminal, where a packet capture tool displayed an error message for interrupting the process, and he immediately recognized the IP address. —Did you- Were you trying to spy on my sister!?

—Just some sniffing to see what I could gather…

—Wait, no! Tha-that's a Man-In-the-Middle attack! To the Head of the faction! I-I should report you!

—*You* will report me, Micah?— she asked, almost mockingly.

—Don't make me…

—I harbour no ill intent against your sister— she assured him, a bit dismissive.

—Then why…

—I am merely *curious* about her, since *she* got the promotion I've been chasing for so long.

—But…

—The oldest notes I have, manifesting my intentions to get Norwyn's place in the faction, date from more than a decade ago. Can you assure me your sister has been after her current

position for a decade too?

—N-no— he had to admit, looking away. —Bu-but still, you can't do this, Light Spinner. —Even if you don't steal or compromise the integrity of whatever information you manage to intercept, you're still breaching the faction's confidentiality. That's a penalized crime.

—I am well aware. Which is why I was scanning your sister's *personal* network and not Mystacor's.

—It's the same! You wouldn't be attacking a faction directly, but by attacking its Head…

—I'd only reveal vulnerabilities in her architecture— she casually interrupted.

—No one is free from vulnerabilities, but the augments my sister installed are… *a lot*. Especially those from Dryl— he scoffed. —There are more chances of her catching you red-handed and rightfully calling security on you, than…

—Than *what*!?

—Never mind— he muttered, looking away. —Just listen to me, Master. You'll only get yourself in trouble if you keep doing this. Forget about my sister and about being Head of Mystacor…

—I have nothing left, Micah! I can't further enhance myself, can't install any more augmentations, *now* can't get the position I have been chasing, and if that weren't enough-Uh…

—What?

—Nothing…

—Please, Light Spinner. Leave my sister alone. I'll help you with *whatever* project you undertake, as long as you forget about her…

The woman didn't answer.

She simply dismissed him with a gesture, returned to her terminal, and closed everything.

Hesitant but deciding this was enough for now, Micah silently left the apartment.

As she heard the door close, she took out an electronic touchscreen the size of a notebook and opened an encrypted file.

She had already gone through these notes a dozen times, but… she couldn't help rereading them.

Never let anything happen to *her*.

Use your improved abilities to keep *her* from harm's way.

You'll know who *she* is.

Give *her* some time.

You made a deal; for *her* own good, *she* has to abide by it.

And invite her a round.

—These stupid notes… Why am I so *cryptic*!?— she angrily muttered, encrypting the file once again before putting away the touchscreen. —It *cannot* be her. Why would someone like *her*, with so many augmentations, and such powerful ones at that, need someone like *me* to look after her!?

It was simply ridiculous.

Since the moment she saw Micah's sister a week before, when her promotion was announced, she couldn't help being impressed, *attracted*, by her prowess… So many augmentations, so many perks… And now she knows just how efficient they are, too.

No, it couldn't be her…

However, that didn't satisfy her curiosity.

How did she *not* know of her before?

Why did she have no notes about Micah's sister?

Who was this woman!?

After some serious investigation that took up most of her resources, Castaspella managed it.

She had found the intruder in less than twenty-four hours.

—Knock, knock!— her brother announced himself, waiting at the doorframe of the office. —May I come in?

—Yes, please, Micah— she invited. —I'm sorry for calling you like that, but this is important.

—Tell me.

—Just yesterday, I had an issue and discovered someone in my network, probably eavesdropping.

—Oh… that…

—You know?

—Yeah…— he admitted, looking away shyly and nervously scratching the back of his neck.

—Then that saves me a lot of explaining— she sighed. —So, *why* was your Master sniffing my personal network?

—Look, Sis, I already told her to leave you alone. I'm sorry about that— he immediately said, apologetic. —I don't- Well, I *do* know why, but I can't- It's just that… Ah… she's a very ambitious woman, and she's been after Norwyn's spot for more than a decade, and…

—So I took that place and her brilliant idea was to commit a *crime*!?

—I know, I *know*! But, please, don't call security on her. I promise she has no bad intentions, Sis. She's just… bitter, I guess— Micah replied, looking resigned.

—After I met her last week- well, kind of "met" her- You understand what I mean… Last week, you told me to stay away from her, but now you say she's inoffensive?

—She's- I mean… *As a person*, she's… *something*, and I wouldn't recommend you cross paths with her because… I'm sure she'd be after your prowess with all the augmentations you have. Alright? I don't want her to use you or anything…

—There's a "but", I reckon?

—There is: *But*, in general, she has no bad intentions. She's just too selfish. She won't do anything to bring harm to you or the faction, I swear.

—Ah… Alright— Castaspella eventually sighed, folding her arms. —I wasn't planning on denouncing her or anything. Don't worry— she promised. —Proper protocol would be to put her under investigation and interrogate her myself, but I decided to call you instead, out of respect, and because the *incident* only affected me as an individual. As long as Mystacor itself isn't threatened, I have no need to follow those protocols.

—I'll let her know and… keep an eye on her in case she does anything stupid like that again — he nodded. —Thanks, Sis.

Unfortunately for the siblings, Light Spinner only took it as a challenge.

She promised to leave Micah's sister alone, and never to attack Mystacor's faction in any way. But the process of information gathering can be executed in many ways, and he never said anything about searching for intel on her in *other* sources…

Hence, she dedicated her free time to this new task.

For a whole month, she followed the breadcrumbs and pieced together Castaspella's profile until it *felt* like she knew her.

She was aware that her idea of the woman was probably far from accurate, yet she had become obsessed, which made her want to know the real her… Especially after finding bits of information that suggested she had worked with Castaspella in the past.

If only she could hack into Mystacor's database…

Alas, she'd never know.

Meanwhile, during that month, the Head of the faction had been carrying out her own investigation.

It was by mere chance that she came across old records of Mystacor listing its most efficient teams, and she was more than surprised to find her name *along* with Light Spinner's in one of them.

Why was her brother so adamant in warning her about his Master if they had worked together for what looked like about two decades!?

He always remarked that the old woman is obsessed with power; insisted that her augmentations would make her a target of Light Spinner's manipulation or something… And he was pretty serious about it.

But she had… this *feeling*… She didn't know what it was, couldn't name it, and desperately wanted to figure it out.

And… what if that note to herself meant- No, no.

Ridiculous.

How would she have a secret relationship with Light Spinner without Micah knowing!?

It couldn't be…

So, what if… she investigated the woman a bit?

Her brother would probably disapprove, of course, so she made sure he wouldn't even suspect.

Which became increasingly difficult the more she learnt.

For example, her real name, Beatrix, was so beautiful to her that she could hardly keep herself from using it when referring to her.

And the fact that she had joined The Horde's faction at some point!?

Not just any time… It had been *right after* being investigated for suspected treason!

How could it be!?

And how exactly had she managed to be recruited by Mystacor again after that!?

She *needed* to know the woman for real.

She had *so many* questions!

Whether she was the person to whom the note to herself referred to, it no longer mattered. Light Spinner had become an obsession to her, which felt *wrong*. So she needed to meet the real her to sublimate that *infatuation*.

If only she could convince her brother to let them meet…

Much as it pained him, much as he tried to deny it and feign madness, he was actually well aware of how his sister and his Master had grown obsessed with each other.

But it couldn't be!

How could the mysterious woman in Castaspella's note to herself be Light Spinner!?

No, no, no.

He-he would *know*! He would have realized!

Right!?

But then… why is he so afraid to let them meet in person?

Why has he been struggling to keep them apart for the past few months?

Perhaps… he *should* present them.

Maybe that would finally confirm they were *nothing more than colleagues*, and so he'll finally find some peace…

Unless it only proved him wrong, of course.

A couple of days later, Micah finally gathered the courage to visit his sister and ask if she would like to formally meet Light Spinner… only to be met with the wildest reply.

—Oh, finally! I thought I would have to get Angella to convince you!

—Wait, *what*!?

—I'm not stupid, Brother. I know you've been coming up with all manner of excuses to keep us as far from each other as possible— Castaspella scoffed, rolling her eyes. —Look, I'm just curious about her. I've found old files in our database that list the best-performing teams in the faction, and *we* used to be one of them! You, me, *and* Light Spinner, along with some others who weren't permanent. A-and for over two decades! At some point, I became the team lead, then gave the position back to her, but… I don't know. It's just that… if we've known each other for so long, why is there nothing about her in my notes!?

—I… know you were good friends, but… Ah… Sis, I'm afraid all she'll see in you now is your prowess— Micah sighed. —Yet it's clear you both want to meet, so I… decided I should present you both myself and, well, if she tries to- I don't know, manipulate you in some way, or-or whatever, I'll stop her.

—Alright— she nodded, slightly upset but understanding what he meant. —Thanks, Brother.

—Of course— he smiled. —Where would you… uh… like to meet?

—Why don't you come home with her? I'll invite you both for some tea or coffee and we can talk— Castaspella proposed.

—Really?

—If you want…

—O-of course, that sounds good— he nodded. —I'm just surprised you'd let her into your place after…

—After her little intrusion the other month?

—Yeah…

—It was nothing, Brother. I believe my augmentations can handle anything she may attempt, in any case— she smugly said, smirking for a second before giggling.

—Alright, I'll tell her you invited us for a chat, then. When should we…

—Tomorrow afternoon? Is that alright?

—I suppose we're all free at that time, yes.

—See you then, Micah— she gently smiled.

—Until then, Sis.

After a similar conversation with Light Spinner, in which she admitted she *also* took notice of how he had been "protecting" his sister, the old woman agreed to attend the following day, and pretended she didn't know Castaspella's address when he asked.

Once that was settled, Micah left the office and she rushed to her terminal. It was quite late, and Light Spinner should be heading home, but she had the sudden urge to check the cameras around the woman's apartment, as if *something* told her she'd find her leaving.

And she did, in fact, catch her leaving the place.

It was the first time she listened to this weird gut feeling and went to check the cameras, however. Now she wondered whether it was an actual alert from her augmentations that

somehow let her know when Castaspella's front door opened and closed.

But it wasn't the time to figure that out. She'd have time some other moment…

Currently, the woman was on the move and Light Spinner felt curious.

Wouldn't hurt to follow her a bit, no?

She promptly switched from camera to camera, never letting her out of her sight, until Castaspella walked into a small restaurant.

—Wait- I…— she spoke up, getting the feeling that she knew that place. Immediately, she switched to her browser and looked it up, only to let out a gasp when she found the name of the place. —Impossible…

She had to return home. *Now*.

The next day, a bit before the arranged time, Light Spinner was preparing herself to visit Castaspella. She had told Micah she'd find him there, so she could go at her own pace, and now realized she felt… *nervous*.

What a disgusting feeling.

Perhaps it was due to her *findings* the previous night.

That restaurant… Why did she have receipts from that place saved in her wooden box?

Why have something so insignificant inside her most important possession, according to her notes?

Well, like it or not, it seemed like Castaspella could know…

Which meant she'd perhaps know about that… *other thing*.

It was worth a shot.

With a deep breath, the old woman picked up the whole box, its key, and tucked everything in her black purse before finally leaving.

—Welcome, Light Spinner.

The Head of the faction spoke gently and smiled softly at her; a stark contrast with how she would behave in her place.

—Curious that you would invite me…— she began, mockingly, yet trailed off upon stepping inside. —Why do I…

—Wait- Why are your biometrics in my system!?— Castaspella interrupted, before she could finish her question. They both exchanged a shocked glance before looking back at Micah, who had gone pale and averted his gaze. —That can't be…

—This has to be a joke— Light Spinner scoffed. —What's next? *Your* biometrics in *my* security system!?

—Um…

—Micah!— the women both exclaimed, indignant, as he attempted to interject.

—I don't like it any more than you! Trust me! Bu-but…

—*But*?— Castaspella insisted.

—That would explain things, right?

—So you knew?— his sister asked, looking a bit betrayed.

—That your augmentations have alarms set on her apartment? Yes… I-I told myself it was impossible, but… I couldn't keep denying it with so much proof!

—You need to tell us everything you know, Micah— Light Spinner demanded.

—I know…— he sighed. —Let's just sit, and I'll tell you what I *think* happened here.

—Ah…— Castaspella exhaled, resigned. —Of course. Coffee?

—Sure— the old woman nodded, before taking a seat in front of the kitchen table.

—Alright, so… I suppose the relevant thing here is that, wild as it may sound, Master, my sister had several augmentations installed all at once recently. Forty, to be precise.

—That's impossible…

—It's not— he insisted, glancing back at Castaspella occasionally, while she brewed some coffee, as offered. —For decades now, you have been installing augments, one after the other, as soon as you got them. But she didn't. She gathered them, and installed them only now so she wouldn't have to restart countless times as *you* have done.

—What are you trying to say?

—I refused to admit it before, didn't want to connect the dots, but now I can't ignore it… My sister kept appearing after each of your installations, always with a different excuse, likely because she aimed to restore the relationship you two had… Without me learning about it.

—Micah… Why would I do that?

Far from taking it seriously, Light Spinner was ready to spit a mocking comment, yet froze up the second Castaspella set the mug of coffee in front of her.

—This…

—What?

—This aroma— she uttered. —How did you prepare this coffee? What does it have?

—I-I just… prepare it how I know. It's almost muscle memory…

—What does it *have*!?

—Coffee grains, very finely grounded, sugar, and this thing- azahar water.

—How the *fuck* do you know how to make this kind of coffee!?— the woman immediately asked, utterly shocked.

—Alright! Alright…— Micah interrupted, raising his hands in a pacifying gesture towards his master. —Remember what I *just* said?

—You mean she must have taught me?

—Exactly— he sighed, resigned. —If… Ah… If you two *were* a couple, it would make sense, yes…

The three remained silent for a moment. Light Spinner sipped her coffee, looking at the distance, while the siblings briefly glanced at each other before averting their gaze, ashamed.

—I think I have further proof of that— the old woman finally said. Setting down her mug, she let out a sigh and then reached for the wooden box in her purse. —I keep important things here, mostly because it can't be hacked… And yet, I couldn't understand why I would keep receipts from a restaurant here. A place I never mention in my notes, which I *thought* meant it wasn't even that relevant to me.

—Or perhaps you wanted to keep it a secret from me— Micah commented, looking dejected.

—Likely— Light Spinner agreed. —I brought it because you happened to visit that same restaurant last night— she then told Castaspella. —I don't even know what those two dishes are… But that means I didn't go alone— she scoffed, before handing her one of the receipts.

—These are just ramen. And, yes, certainly from that shop…

—Any chance you could have been the one who went with me?

—Most likely— she had to admit, chuckling a bit. —Shio Ramen is my favourite one from that place.

—I see…

—Well, but… Eating at the same place doesn't prove much…— Castaspella was arguing, until Light Spinner took something *else* out of the box.

—What about this, then?

The siblings were both equally shocked, staring at the ring, mouth agape.

There was no mistaking it: that looked like an engagement ring.

—But- Wait, just because it was with the receipts…— the woman began, yet trailed off, realizing it actually made sense. —I-I suppose… Bu-but maybe it *is* just a coincidence. Perhaps you're reading too much into a simple fifty-eight point nineteen order, and- Oh…

—What?— Micah questioned, interested in whatever she had realized.

—Oh, shit— Castaspella muttered, before rushing to her room.

—What did I miss?— he asked, now looking at Light Spinner as if she had caught something he didn't.

—She's *your* sister. If you don't know…— she mockingly replied, finishing her coffee.

—I suppose you were right— she sighed, finally returning to the kitchen carrying a paper notebook and something in her closed hand. —I found a safe in my room that needed a four-digit key, but I couldn't find it… And the only hint was a bunch of letters that meant nothing to me… until now.

—I'm not following— Micah denied, shaking his head.

—The receipts. The letters from the hint are an acronym of the order and the restaurant's name. The first letter of each word! A-and the price- That was the pin to open the safe— she explained, taking a deep breath.

She looked nervous, or rather, anxious, and wouldn't look at them.

—Sis, take a seat and calm down— he suggested, concerned. —What do you have there?

—These… were inside— she replied, sitting down and placing the notebook on the table. After a moment, she slowly opened her hand to reveal a ring matching Light Spinner's. Only then did she look back at them, saying —I'm starting to think I was only supposed to get them from the safe if something like *this* happened… I don't have the pin in my notes, or any receipts like that from the ramen shop, not even a reference to it… A-and the note to myself mentioned I purposely left some things out…

—So, perhaps, a part of you hoped to return with her, despite whatever she may have done to make you erase her like that— Micah reflected. He then let out a long sigh, stood up, and concluded —I suppose I should leave you two to read that, which I guess is a record of your relationship, and… well, whatever you decide, I won't interfere anymore. I've already kept you apart long enough…

With that, he aimed for the door, and only stopped before opening to farewell.

—Thank you, Brother— Castaspella nodded with a small smile. He nodded in reply, smirking a bit, and finally left. —I- Um, do you want to… know what this says? Or… would you rather we pretend none of this ever happened?— she shyly asked Light Spinner. —I don't want to get you involved unless you- I mean, I would understand if you didn't want to know what happened before all the augmentations and…

—I most definitely want to know— the old woman interrupted. —I've been searching for answers for a long while, which kept driving me insane, and *you* have them. I'm not leaving until I learn everything.

—A-alright. That's fair— Castaspella accepted, blushing slightly. —Then, let's see…— she nodded, opening the journal between them.

Just as expected, *everything* was there.

From how they met, and how they began their secret relationship, to the repeated reintroductions.

Castaspella had begun recording it all since Light Spinner's first augmentation, apparently because she feared the day she would install hers too. After summarizing the first seven years together, she switched to more detailed entries explaining her progress with restoring Light Spinner's memories about their relationship.

Judging by the size of the notebook, and the fact that it was full, they realized it meant the woman had really done this at least thirty-nine times, for around twenty years…

—Then why would you- Why did you give up after so long?

—The note to myself says I couldn't take it anymore, and that I had to let you continue resetting without… Well, without suffering…

—And you did it *precisely* when I installed my last augmentation— Light Spinner scoffed. —I suppose you couldn't have known what my health report would say, but… how ironic…

—You- Oh, Stars… That's some cruel irony— she agreed. —But I can read in these entries how much I hurt, especially in the second half…

—That's my answer then… But perhaps you should have done so way earlier.

—Which, it seems, you told me back then, yes— Castaspella sighed. —Still, I find it so hard to believe I did this after all the effort I put into the relationship. I seemed so happy after you proposed, and in the whole journal, e-even when hurting, I sound so hopeful!

—And stubborn…

—Yes— she chuckled. —On the contrary, my note to myself was… I don't know what's the word. Broken-hearted, depressing, melancholic…

—It also sounds like I never spared a thought for you before restarting so many times— Light Spinner noted, shaking her head. —I'd say you made the right choice by forgetting me-us…

After a moment of silence, in which Castaspella kept her sight down, she eventually replied —And if I disagree?

The old woman stared at her in shock until she looked back, determined.

—Are you sure?

—I think it's now the right time— she insisted. —Neither of us can install anymore, so…

—You can't either?

—I got forty of them, all together, which I knew could be perilous, but it was my decision… I thought, if everything went fine, it'd be proof that I could keep installing if I got any more augments in the future, but my age, for a human, is already in the health-risk range.

—Yes, my age was also the problem for me, despite me being of a long-lived species…

—Ah…— Castaspella sighed. —Look, I won't force you if you would rather not, but I think the conditions are perfect now to try again… And it won't be secret this time, which may be easier than how it used to be.

—I suppose we could give it a chance, yes— the old woman nodded. —But if it doesn't work…

—We'll see how we handle it when, *or if*, it happens.

—Very well— she smirked. —I think we should start by getting to know each other? The *real* ones, I mean…

—You investigated me too.

—Of course.

—By all means, I'd like to know the real you— the woman chuckled.

—Good then— the Light Spinner nodded, standing up. She then turned and stretched out her hand to Castaspella to help her up, offering —How does dinner sound? This round is on me.

Chapter End Notes

Well, that was all ^_^

I hope you enjoyed the ride, and the ending :D

This chapter was super difficult, really...
So I sure af hope you liked it (/^\)

Oh, btw, here you can see the tattoo I got today, literally a reference to *In The Shadows of Mystacor*!

I don't know what else to say, tbh, I already said what I'm doing rn hahahha so <("^_^)

Bye!!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!